unique to offer, in their energy, their hope and in their shared future.[8] In addition, the fact that Bhagat Singh, Ram Prasad Bismil and Ashfaqullah 'remained within the influence of poetry . . . even at the moment of death' is widely heralded, as Simona Sawhney makes plain. Even McKinley, the British officer at the time, recorded in his diary, 'I think it was the poetry that held their souls together, as the torture tore their bodies apart.'[9] Yet, it is clear that it was not just poetry, but literature too, and in particular Russian literature.

Bhagat Singh gave Sukhdev an example from his own life, when an attempt was made by intelligence officers to cajole him into becoming an informant and to thereby save his life. He spurned the offer contemptuously, explaining that he had ideals:

> When I was brought here from Delhi for the purpose of identification, some intelligence officers talked to me . . . in the presence of my father. They said that since I did not try to save my life by divulging secrets, it proved the presence of an acute agony in my life. They argued that death of this kind will be something like suicide. But I had replied that a man with beliefs and ideals like mine, could never think of dying uselessly. We want to get the maximum value for our lives. We want to serve humanity as much as possible. Particularly a man like me, whose life is nowhere sad or worried . . .[10]

The proceedings before the special tribunal having ended, and with the verdict awaited in keen anticipation by all, Bhagat Singh now made a revelation of remarkable sincerity, saying, 'I hope you will permit me to tell you what I think about myself. I am certain of capital punishment for me. I do not expect even a bit of moderation or amnesty.' In this sense, he was ahead of the game because it is startlingly revealing from this that he knew from the beginning what awaited him. This being so, he set out from the outset to embrace death, believing that '[a] revolution can be achieved only through sustained striving, sufferings and sacrifices. And it shall be achieved'. He wished to end his struggle in a manner whereby 'some indelible impressions are made on the hearts of the people of the country through our hanging. Only this much and nothing more'.[11] This is why Simona Sawhney is able to say that '[w]hat makes him such a powerful icon today' according to her 'is less his writing or beliefs, and more the very